

Read Building Effective Agents (below). In your own words, write the difference between a workflow and an agent, and classify your FL-04 pipeline as one or the other.

Agent is a term used to identify a LLM that decides the steps to take and how to carry out a process based on a user's input, whereas workflow is used to define a LLM that carry out a process based on predefined tools and codes. The FL-04 pipeline is a workflow because the stages it uses to get to an output are predefined, i.e. it is not independently choosing the path.

Write a 600-to-900-word explainer: what an agent is, what MCP is, what your FL-04 workflow would need to become an agent.

An agent is an AI system in which an LLM dynamically determines the steps and tools needed to accomplish a task. It is equipped to deal with open-ended tasks. It can decide which tools to use, the number of iterations needed, and the steps necessary to reach the desired output. The agent typically receives an initial goal or instruction from a human. However, human intervention may be needed again if the AI requires clarification, approval or a decision that lies outside the agent's capabilities. Anthropic defines agents as working in loops with potential stopping points needing human intervention. It is to be noted that clear user instructions improve the agent's performance and remove ambiguity which increases the output's accuracy.

Model Context Protocol (MCP) provides a standardised way for multiple AI clients such as Claude to access external tools, data sources and services. One way to use MCP with an AI application such as Claude is to download the Desktop app but it can be used in other ways with other clients. MCP allows AI to interact with the system's local files that the user provides access to. For example, MCP can allow an AI application to access a local Word document that the user has explicitly made available.

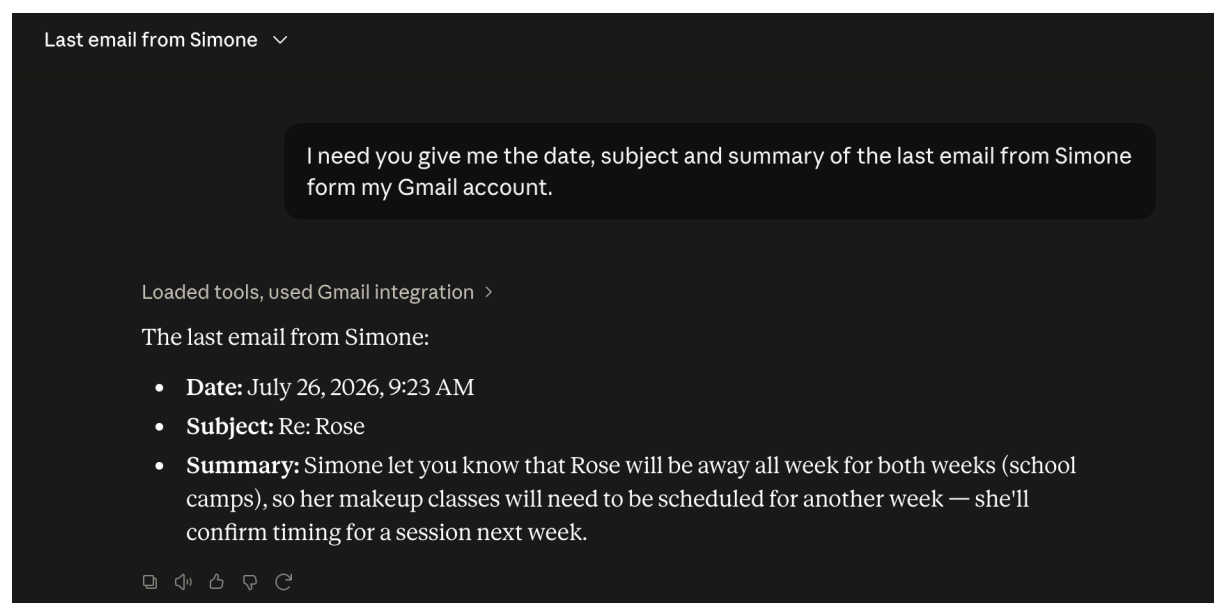
It starts with the LLM which connects with the MCP client which connects with the MCP server and finally to the external tool or data. To use MCP effectively and efficiently we need three primitives. They are tools, resources and prompts. Tools refer to the action that the AI can invoke depending on the prompt that's given through the MCP server. Resources refer to the data that the AI can access (example, a Word file). Prompts are reusable prompt templates or instructions that an MCP server provides to the AI application for the defined tasks.

While MCPs can aid the agent in carrying out tasks in the background, it does have restrictions. Depending on the MCP client and its respective configuration, users may be asked for permission before specific actions are executed. This ensures that

actions with significant consequences, for example an online payment, is provided with a safety control in the form of human approval.

The current FL-04 pipeline is only a workflow as the stages the AI uses are predefined. The AI can execute the individual instruction, but it does not independently determine the sequence of stages. To give it that independence, to make it an agent, the current pipeline (Gather → Synthesise → Draft → Critique → Revise → Human Review) would need to change, such that when a user provides a topic, the agent first analyses the task it has. After that it assesses what information is provided and what is additionally needed to produce the output before gathering the appropriate sources. The agent should then evaluate whether the gathered information is valid and enough to carry out the task. If so, it continues with the next steps. If not, it carries out further research. Once it is confident in the information collected, it synthesises it and makes an appropriate draft. It then critiques its own draft and determines whether revision is necessary. If weaknesses remain, it revises the draft and evaluates it again. This loop continues until the agent determines the output that fulfils the required criteria after which it displays the result for human review. If not, it reiterates. The key difference is that, in the agent version, the AI dynamically controls the transitions between stages based on the information it obtains and the results of its previous actions, rather than following a fixed sequence determined in advance.

Connect one MCP server or connector to Claude (any MCP client counts). Run three tasks through it that chat alone could not do, like reading local files or querying a live service.



The screenshot shows a chat window with a dark background. At the top, it says "Last email from Simone" with a dropdown arrow. Below this, a user message in a light blue bubble says: "I need you give me the date, subject and summary of the last email from Simone form my Gmail account." Below the user message, it says "Loaded tools, used Gmail integration" with a right-pointing arrow. Then, the AI's response says: "The last email from Simone:" followed by a bulleted list:

- **Date:** July 26, 2026, 9:23 AM
- **Subject:** Re: Rose
- **Summary:** Simone let you know that Rose will be away all week for both weeks (school camps), so her makeup classes will need to be scheduled for another week — she'll confirm timing for a session next week.

 At the bottom of the chat window, there are several small icons: a square, a speech bubble, a heart, a star, and a circular arrow.

i need you to access my calendar and tell me all the sessions i have this week.

Reconciled calendar data with conflicting cancellation information

Here are your sessions this week (all times shown in your calendar's timezone, Asia/Dubai):

- **Monday, July 27 - 10:00-11:00 AM:** Rose's Session
- **Monday, July 27 - 11:00 AM-12:00 PM:** Rose (Zoom meeting)
- **Saturday, August 1 - 12:00-12:30 PM:** Otto (Zoom meeting)

One thing worth flagging: Simone emailed you earlier today saying Rose won't be doing classes this Tuesday or on August 11 due to school camp — but your calendar doesn't actually show a Tuesday session, so that note may refer to a different week or a session not on this calendar. Worth double-checking with her if you're unsure.

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i need you to give me the links for the ZOOM meetings for Rose and Otto

Here are the Zoom links from your calendar:

- **Rose** (Mon, July 27, 11:00-12:00 AM+04:00): <https://us04web.zoom.us/j/72164873885?pwd=bPtTGikZFWAJ9cIvbmYWlHY4qEupyD.1> (Meeting ID: 721 6487 3885, Passcode: 4gLdkw)
- **Otto** (Sat, Aug 1, 12:00-12:30 PM+04:00): <https://us04web.zoom.us/j/76103593086?pwd=GzE25xaCgQxIU8HOFHuSIq6SwmUDET.1> (Meeting ID: 761 0359 3086, Passcode: 7UmaPG)

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